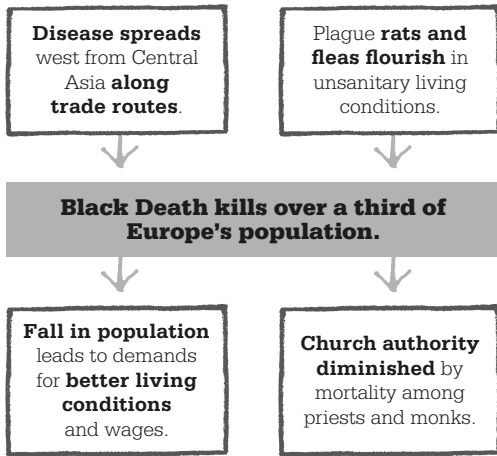




More than a hundred million people may have died of the plague; estimates put the world population at 450 million before it arrived, and 350 million afterward. Its effects were more deadly in some areas than in others—in Egypt, about 40 percent of the population are thought to have died. Populations did not reach pre-plague levels again for nearly three centuries.

Reactions to the plague

Survivors reacted in varying ways. Jewish communities in Germany were accused of causing the plague by poisoning wells, and many were attacked. In Strasbourg alone, 2,000 Jews were killed.

With the population diminished, landholdings fell vacant, labor became scarce, and peasants' bargaining power increased. By 1350, English laborers could demand five times the wages they had asked in 1347, and tenants were paying rent in cash rather than with compulsory labor. Governments tried to clamp down on wages—the 1351 Statute of Labourers aimed to freeze rates at 1346 levels—but peasants responded with outbursts such as the Jacquerie in France in 1358, and the Peasants' Revolt in England in 1381.

By the time it ended, the Black Death had killed proportionately as many clergy as laity, and some clergy deserted their posts. As a result the church's authority, like that of the nobility, was greatly weakened. The plague had loosened the ties that had previously bound medieval society together, leaving a freer and more volatile population to face the challenges posed by the Renaissance, Reformation, and the economic expansion of the 16th and 17th centuries. ■

Shattered society

The plague's catastrophic toll cast a long shadow over contemporary social attitudes. A landscape of mass graves, abandoned villages, and an all-pervading fear of death deepened the sense that God had abandoned his people, and diluted the claims of traditional morality. Crime rose: the incidence of murder in England doubled in two decades from 1349. Flagellants roamed the countryside, scourging themselves with knotted ropes, until a Papal bull banned the practice in 1349. Bequests to charitable foundations—hospitals in particular—rose as the rich gave thanks for their survival. Artistic production tended to the morbid: depictions of the Dance of Death appeared, showing Death cavorting among the living; and writers such as Boccaccio, who chronicled the plague in his *Decameron*, stressed the briefness and fragility of life.



Death selects his victims indiscriminately from among the social orders in the allegorical *Danse Macabre* or Dance of Death.